CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ILLUSTRATOR IN THE AI ERA

This is the one job where the AI's output and your output are the same object. The demand data isn't ambiguous, and it isn't kind.

★ **TL;DR — Our take: NO. The BLS proxy occupation (Craft and Fine Artists) medians $55,290 and is declining −1%, with all ~4,300 yearly openings replacement-only — and the freelance market where most illustrators actually sell is measurably worse than the proxy.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$55K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK MEDIUM

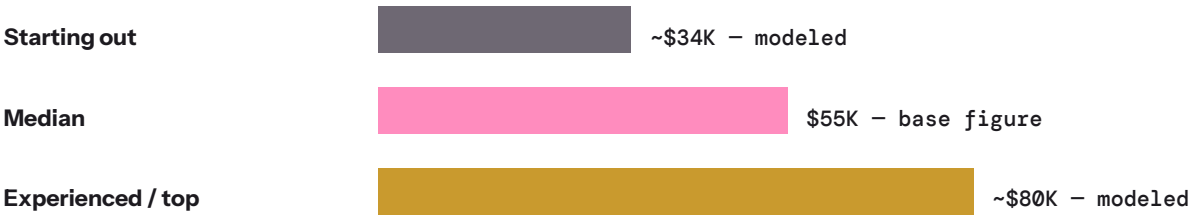
- The official line: illustrators are counted inside Craft and Fine Artists — $55,290 median, −1% growth, and BLS states plainly that all of the openings come from replacing workers who leave. There is no growth layer to enter.

- The platform data is peer-reviewed and brutal: after image generators arrived, job posts for image creation fell ~17% (Demirci, Hannane & Zhu, Management Science 2025), and individual image freelancers' earnings fell 9.4% in the short run (Hui, Reshef & Zhou, Organization Science 2024).

- The workers confirm it: in the Society of Authors' survey, 37% of illustrators said their income had already decreased because of generative AI, and 78% expected it to reduce their future income.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Illustrator is a ~$55K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are

modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A ILLUSTRATOR ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Develop concepts, thumbnails and sketches for client approval
- ✓ Produce finished illustrations for books, editorial, products and brands
- ✓ Revise through rounds of feedback without losing the piece
- ✓ License usage rights — historically half the business model

Think: a translator who turns words into one specific visual voice — in a market where the listener just got a free translator that speaks every voice at once, adequately.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
The finished image itself: stock-style spots, backgrounds, concepts, variants, quick commercial pieces. This is the one occupation in the library where the tool doesn't take tasks around the product — it takes the product.	Reputation businesses: named editorial and children's-book artists with an audience, live and event illustration, artisanal print craft. Real incomes exist there — built over years of name-building, which is a business launch, not an entry a roadmap can sell.

⚠ **The proxy flatters you. $55,290 is an employee median inside a declining occupation; most illustrators are freelance, selling into the exact platform market where posts fell 17% and earnings 9.4% after the generators landed. Plan against the market you'd actually enter, not the statistic that sounds better.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Quiet, deep-focus craft with a devoted culture around it ✓ A distinctive style compounds like a reputation asset ✓ Live, print and audience-driven corners still pay	✗ The beginner's exact product is the generators' launch demo ✗ Income is project-based, uneven, and shrinking at the entry tier ✗ Licensing leverage weakens when the client's alternative is nearly free

Good fit? Already have the audience or the name — repeat buyers, a following, a signature the market asks for by name. You're defending a business, not starting a career, and this map isn't addressed to you.

Bad fit? Anyone starting in 2027 planning to sell generic commercial illustration into open marketplaces. That demand curve has been measured, and it points down.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO UX/UI Designer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Video Editor
Your visual judgment, repriced by a growing occupation: BLS Web Developers and Digital Designers median $99,520 blended (+5% growth, ~13,600 openings a year) — nearly double the illustrator proxy, in the tier where design means decisions, not deliverables. Illustrators start with the hardest part already trained: composition, hierarchy, visual storytelling. What you add is the product layer — flows, prototypes, usability, systems. First move: take one illustrated project and rebuild it as a product case: problem, flow, interface, result.	Still images taught you the frame; moving frames still hire. BLS Film and Video Editors median $75,420, growth +3% — an occupation that absorbed AI into its assistant layer and kept growing. Every brand that once commissioned spot illustrations now commissions motion, and editors are hired from reels, not résumés. First move: animate one of your own illustrations into a 30-second piece and cut it properly — your eye is the credential, the timeline is the new canvas.

Smart move: Keep drawing — as the differentiator, not the deliverable. An interface designer who can actually draw, or an editor with an illustrator's eye, beats both purebreds. The style is your edge inside a growing job, not a product in a shrinking one.

Where you land after: You land where the eye is bought as judgment: product interfaces at a $99K blended median, or editing timelines at $75K and growing — with illustration as the signature nobody else in the room has.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	LEARN THE	REBUILD ONE	LEARN TO	SHIP PROOF	APPLY WHERE

STEP 1 — Read the measured decline

TODAY · FREE

- Look at the two platform numbers yourself: image posts −17%, image-freelancer earnings −9.4% post-generators.
- Audit your last ten would-be commissions: which could the client now generate acceptably?

STEP 2 — Learn the product layer

WEEKS 1-4

- UX fundamentals: goals, flows, hierarchy inside interfaces, usability heuristics.
- Figma to clickable-prototype depth — your composition skills transfer faster than you think.

STEP 3 — Rebuild one project as a product case

MONTHS 1-2

- Take an illustrated project and redesign it as a working product flow.
- Write the case as decisions and outcomes, not process pictures.

STEP 4 — Learn to cut

MONTHS 2-3

- Premiere or DaVinci Resolve basics: pacing, audio, titles, colour.
- Turn one of your illustrations into a finished 30-second motion piece.

STEP 5 — Ship proof in both doors

MONTHS 3-4

- One product case and two edited pieces, finished and public.
- Take any paid design or editing gig that ships — reps beat plans.

STEP 6 — Apply where images are decisions

MONTHS 4-6

- Target UX/UI and editor postings; lead with the case and the reel.
- Pitch your illustration as the signature skill inside the role, never as the whole offer.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the −17% yourself. Then open Figma — the eye moves house, it doesn't retire.

□ Days 1–30: UX fundamentals and Figma depth; audit which of your products a client can now generate.

□ Days 31–60: one product case rebuilt from your own work; first motion piece cut.

□ Days 61–90: portfolio relaunched around decisions and timelines; applications out to UX/UI and editor roles.

□ Day 90: you're a visual designer who edits — in growing occupations — not a freelancer bidding against a generator.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **THE EYE SURVIVES. THE IMAGE MARKET DIDN'T.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.